

Maamarei Mordechai

הסבר לפי ממש פשוט

Parshas Devarim 5786

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Moshe teaches amazing lessons lot by how he recounts prior events.

וָאֶקַח אֶת־רֹאשֵׁי שְׁבִטֵיכֶם אֲנָשִׁים חֲכָמִים וַיִּדְעוּם וְאַתָּן אוֹתָם רֹאשִׁים עֲלֵיכֶם שָׂרֵי
אַלְפִים וְשָׂרֵי מֵאוֹת וְשָׂרֵי חֲמִשִּׁים וְשָׂרֵי עֶשְׂרֵת וְשֹׁטְרִים לְשִׁבְטֵיכֶם:

“And I took the leaders of the tribes, men who were wise and knowledgeable, and I gave them to you as leaders upon you; chamberlains of a thousand, chamberlains of a hundred, chamberlains of fifty, and chamberlains of ten, and officials for the tribes.” (Devarim 1:15).

Moshe recounts how he appointed judges and leaders to help him adjudicate issues among the nation. However, if he was referring to those that helped him prior to Har Sinai, that was based on Yisro’s advice. (Shmos 18:14). If he is referring to the seventy elders that were given divine inspiration, Hashem appointed them when Moshe complained. (Bamidbar 11:16). Also, they were only seventy, and the math does not really work out that seventy people can cover the number of judges needed.

Calculate 600,000 people in the nation, it would require 300 judges over thousands, 3,000 over hundreds, 6,000 over fifties, and 30,000 over tens. The reason it is not double that, is because it takes two litigants per case. It is not one judge over a thousand people. It is really one judge over a thousand cases, at least 2,000 people. That would still require 39,300 judges. Also, the Torah does not say “judges.” Here it reflects the language that it says before of “chamberlains” but it says leaders from the tribes. The prior narrative says choose from Yisroel as a whole. (Shmos 18:25).

In fact, 39,300 judges were not needed. Not everyone in the nation had a dispute. In reality, only small percentages of people actually engage in litigation. Therefore, the judge of tens is ten cases, not twenty litigants. Therefore, it is possible that seventy wise and knowledgeable leaders, taken from the tribes – from among Yisroel – can cover the government/judiciary positions needed to accomplish this goal. Yisro had the advice and Hashem inspired the leaders. There is another way to view the recounting.

A remarkable feature of Sefer Devarim is that Moshe does not simply repeat the Torah's earlier narratives. At first glance, this can be unsettling as events are condensed, details are omitted, emphases shift, and sometimes Moshe recounts an episode in a way that seems to differs from how it was originally presented. This is not because Moshe forgot the details, nor because the Torah is inconsistent. Rather, Moshe is no longer recording history as it unfolded. Standing on the plains of Moav, just days before his death, he is preparing a new generation to enter Eretz Yisrael.

One of the clearest examples is the leadership narrative. Moshe commenced with "I said to you at that time, 'I cannot bear you alone.'" (Devarim 1:9). This is Bamidbar where Moshe says he cannot bear them alone. (Bamidbar 11:14). Yet, our pasuk about the

chamberlains over amounts of cases corresponds to Yisro. (Shmos 18:21). Were they perhaps the same episode told from two different points of view in the Torah?

Yisro's advice was judicial efficiency. Hashem's response to Moshe's complaint does not describe judges. There, Moshe is not overwhelmed by lawsuits but by the emotional and spiritual burden of leading the nation. He even asked Hashem to take his life rather than he continue alone. Hashem's solution is not a judicial system but seventy elders upon whom He places some of Moshe's spirit so they can help bear the burden of leadership. The differences between the two earlier narratives are significant. In Shemos 18, the problem is judicial overload and the solution comes through Yisro's practical advice. In Bamidbar 11, the problem is spiritual and emotional exhaustion and the solution comes directly from Hashem.

These are not contradictory accounts. They address different needs and possibly describe different moments in Bnei Yisroel's journey. If so, why does Moshe sandwich them together? After forty years in the wilderness, Moshe is no longer interested in separating administrative history from spiritual history. Both episodes taught the same enduring truth: no single human being can lead the nation alone. The Torah itself reinforces this synthesis. After describing the appointment of the judges, Moshe does something that neither Shemos nor Bamidbar emphasizes. He records the charge he gave them: "Hear the cases between your brothers and judge righteously...do not show favoritism in judgment... do not fear any man, for the judgment belongs to the Lord." (Devarim 1:16-17). The emphasis has shifted from how the leaders were appointed to how they must lead.

One further question remains. Why does Moshe repeatedly speak in the first person? "I said to you," "I took," "I commanded your judges." Yet in the earlier narratives, the initiative came from Yisro or from Hashem. Throughout Sefer Devarim, Moshe consistently focuses on the outcome rather than the process. His purpose is not to identify who first proposed a system of leadership. His purpose is to remind Bnei Yisroel that these leaders became part of the Torah community through his own implementation and instruction. Still, why not accurately give the credit?

Moshe knew the buck stopped with him. Yisro may have provided wise counsel. Hashem endowed the elders with His Spirit. But it was Moshe who taught the judges, commissioned the leaders, and bore responsibility for forming Bnei Yisroel into a nation governed by justice. Despite where ideas come from, the leader is responsible for executing them efficiently. Moshe is speaking as the shepherd, reflecting on what he learned over forty years of leadership. He took personal responsibility for the decisions he enacted. Perhaps this is the deepest lesson of the parsah. Leadership is never about one person carrying the entire burden. It requires wisdom from others, guidance from Hashem, and faithful leaders throughout the nation. The greatest leader in Jewish history eventually discovered that even he could not lead alone.

As Bnei Yisroel stood ready to enter the Land without Moshe, this is precisely the lesson they needed to hear. That remains a timeless lesson. Klal Yisroel flourishes when capable men and women share the burden in humility, recognizing that all authority is ultimately exercised in the service of Hashem.